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Peter Ecklund

Cornetist Peter Ecklund was born in 1945. He honed his skills in a variety of ensembles, from big bands to classical settings. His recording credits include releases with Marty Grosz, The Grateful Dead, and his own CDs on Arbors Records. He speaks eloquently about the act of improvising and the realities of the business of music. Peter currently resides in New York City, and he can be heard at jazz parties and festivals both here and abroad.

Peter was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 14, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at the San Diego Jazz Party in San Diego, California. I'm pleased to have Peter Ecklund, cornetist, and I hear sometimes whistler—

PE: Yes, cornetist, and private guitarist also.

MR: Private guitarist, okay.

PE: Yes.

MR: —as my guest today. Can I ask you about your instrument first?

PE: Yeah.

MR: It's a cool looking one.

PE: Well this, actually it was made maybe 75 miles from here in Fullerton. And I think it's a copy of an old instrument, I really don't know what. I've tried to get the guy who built it on the phone but I haven't succeeded. But basically the reason I play this, in small groups it's got, I've always played trumpet in big bands, but this, the low notes come out better. And it has I think a more interesting sound as a solo voice. I mean there's not a big difference between cornet and trumpet and you can get trumpets that sound like cornets and cornets that sound like trumpets. But in general it's a bit mellower, and there is more variety in sound that you can get out of it, between the mellowest and the brightest sound. So you can be a little bit, sort of more vocal on it. It's not a huge difference. It's not as easy to play the high notes, but the low notes sound better.

MR: As a matter of fact you mentioned playing a high note, I noticed on one of the tunes I just heard you play down there, I think it was "I'm in the Mood for Love," and they got to the end of that and you were playing the melody in the lead, and it ended up on a pretty high note.

PE: Well that's sort of a standard, I mean you could say it's a cheap trick but it generally works, particularly in a kind of semi-chaotic situation like that. If you can find a good

sounding high note and hold it at the end then it kind of doesn't matter what happens, it kind of covers over everything.

MR: It attracts attention. Yeah, and as you said it was semi-chaotic, as the band kind of found the end there, I wondered how long they were going to keep you hanging up there.

PE: Well I took a good breath before I started, I knew it was going to be a while.

MR: Yeah, you knew what was going to happen. Well we'll talk some more about that. When you meet someone new, and get into a conversation with them, if they have no idea who you are, and if they ask you what you do for a profession, do you have a short answer and a long answer?

PE: Well I say I'm a musician.

MR: And does that then say oh, well, what kind of music do you play?

PE: And then I say I play old jazz and I play commercial music.

MR: Now the music that you were playing earlier, is that old jazz for you?

PE: Yeah. I do more of that than any other kind of music. But I've always considered myself a musician rather than a jazz musician. I mean I don't like calling myself a jazz musician to people because they have a whole list of expectations about how I'm supposed to be, most of which I probably don't satisfy. So rather than disappointing them I just prefer to call myself a musician.

MR: What kind of expectations do you think they have? Lifestyle?

PE: Well like the older people expect Wild Bill Davison or something like that. And the younger people expect kind of the whole bebop, not the music but kind of the character, I mean that sort of thing, and the bebop character and attitude.

MR: You mentioned Wild Bill Davison and I wonder, do you fit yourself into a line of trumpet players do you think? Were there people that you listened to when you were coming up learning the instrument, that became part of your sound?

PE: Oh yeah. I mean every musician who plays improvised music goes through this, I mean you have to in order to — improvising, creating an improvising style is kind of like creating your personal language. And you have to kind of put together your vocabulary. It's kind of a language that only you speak. And you put it together out of various things that you hear around you. And so sure, I mean I played nothing but classical music until I was almost finished with college. But I always listened to a lot of jazz, traditional jazz and like Miles Davis and like that. And I got interested in traditional jazz because the father of a friend of mine had a very good record collection and was interested in that, and my friend played trombone, and he played trumpet. And he had played with Rudy Vallee's orchestra back in the 1920s so he knew a lot of those old songs and like that.

MR: Was there one particular person, a jazz trumpeter that made you really sit up and say that's somebody I'd really like to sound like?

PE: Well I guess I liked Bix Beiderbecke and Louis Armstrong back in those days, and of course I still do now.

MR: I had a feeling you might say that, listening to what you play, that I could hear that in your sound. Can you explain — this is always a tough question — in fact you came through the classical school.

PE: Right.

MR: If you were explaining to a person who knew music pretty well but just had no idea how musicians go about improvising, the thought process, when you're playing on "Ain't Misbehavin'" for instance, can you describe what you're thinking while you're playing?

PE: Yeah, you know I've thought about that a lot since I've been teaching improvising. For the past four or five years, I've been teaching maybe three weeks a year at a camp run by a violinist named Jay Unger who does a lot of Ken Burns' scores for like the "Civil War" and like that, and teaching people who can play but don't improvise. It's a combination of things. One is having things to play, like little stuff that you can play if you can't think of anything better to play; then knowing not really the chords of the songs so much as how the voices move in the song. If you play a one note at a time instrument that's really what you're doing. You're not thinking like C seven to F seven, although you know that's going on, you're thinking like what voice moves to which and how a note is going to sound in a particular harmonic setting as you're playing along. And then what I tell my students is even more important than knowing every chord is knowing where you are in the song. I mean that's really more important than anything.

MR: Knowing the form and feeling where you're at.

PE: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have an occasion on any of these parties where that goes out the window?

PE: Well there are certain tunes that are two sixteen bar patterns that are almost the same. And that can happen like during a drum solo or something, you really have to just remember where you are. But the musicians that do these parties are very good. I'd say that happens very rarely.

MR: Rarely. Did you know every tune they played that first set?

PE: Yeah.

MR: You did. I saw at one point, in fact I heard a couple of key changes tonight. And I don't usually hear that. In fact I saw you in the middle of one tune, I think it was after Marty Grosz had sang it through, that you physically went out, and went like this to the band.

PE: Exactly yeah. Everyone has to know before it happens or you're in trouble.

MR: Were you going to two sharps? Is that what you were doing?

PE: Two flats.

MR: You were going to two flats?

PE: Well you're right, that is the universal symbol for sharps is this and flats is that. But in fact it's too difficult to do that, like if everyone's standing up you can't go like this. And nearly everything we play is either in C or in flat keys. We're not going to play anything in D. We might play something in the key of G.

MR: That's interesting.

PE: So since, well it's because of these instruments. They're made in flat keys. Clarinets and trombones and saxes. So since it's very unlikely you can just hold up fingers and people will know that chances are it's flats.

MR: I wonder how many people in the audience knew what you were doing.

PE: Probably not too many. But modulations are good. It's a way—

MR: Yeah, oh, yeah it was a real refreshing thing.

PE: It changes the texture immediately just because it puts all the instruments in different registers so it's a way of bringing some variety into the sound.

MR: A typical week — where do you live?

PE: New York City.

MR: Okay. And you were born when?

PE: 1945.

MR: Okay. So how come when you were oh twelve years old, in 1957, how come you didn't get into Rock & roll? Or did you?

PE: Well I didn't hear any. I mean my parents had classical music and they had Broadway music and that was about it. And Rock & roll, I mean it was very strong at that time, but it kind of didn't have the respectability among people who thought they were intellectuals that it had just a few years later, like when I went to college. It was kind of a hoodlums and juvenile delinquents' music.

MR: "Blackboard Jungle."

PE: Right. It's funny. It's like it occupied the same role that rap music occupies now. But I mean The Beatles came out I guess just before I entered college. And that really changed everything, that meant that Rock took over popular music. But I really I mean I was familiar with it but it wasn't a big part of my life. I just heard classical music and Broadway shows, Broadway music.

MR: Were your parents supportive of your music endeavors?

PE: Yeah. I mean I'm not so sure they were so happy when I became a musician, that was many years later, but they certainly supported my musical endeavors. I mean I was really doing nothing but classical music then, but I was interested in jazz, and listened to it a fair amount.

MR: So a typical week for a trumpet player and cornet player, living in New York City, could be what?

PE: Well I can tell you my weeks. Everyone, especially now because the music business is so fragmented, everyone really does different things it seems. Maybe I do more than most, but I think it's not that atypical. Let's see. Next week I return to New York on Monday and I play at a place called Michael's Pub, operated by the original owner of Michael's Pub, and it's basically a scam, it's a way of getting tourists who don't realize that Woody Allen has moved on to another place, to come out and thinking that he might be there. But it's a job so I'm doing it.

MR: Yeah. Sure. Were you playing when Woody Allen was there?

PE: From time to time. I wasn't doing it all the time but I did play with him maybe eight or ten times a year and I played on one of his recordings, but I haven't played with him in a number of years.

MR: How does he play?

PE: He's not really a very good musician but in a way he is because he really understands kind of where that music is coming from, he just doesn't have very many skills. But I think in terms of his perception of how it's supposed to feel, he's really pretty good. And it's certainly the strangest job I've ever done, by far. It's the strangest — I mean any musician will tell you that. Because it's not really about music. Whenever I played at the old Michael's Pub, people were always going like this, because being up there, I was in the way so they couldn't see him. And I mean—

MR: They were looking at you.

PE: And I was always waiting for someone to take out a silver handle revolver or something, because, I mean celebrities. I would imagine Woody was thinking about that all the time too.

MR: So he wanted you to stay right in front of him. You stay right where you are.

PE: You've got it.

MR: Oh, that's interesting. And that was pretty straight forward Dixieland?

PE: That was New Orleans revival style, that's what he likes. He plays kind of like George Lewis. That's the music I heard in the late '60s when I was in college. I made a lot of trips to New Orleans on vacations and heard some of that music when it was still pretty decent, at Preservation Hall and all that, and that was really a great experience.

MR: Well I want to come back to that for a minute, but we're just at the beginning of your week, and you've done that gig, and what's next on your calendar?

PE: Then the following day I go up to near Woodstock, New York, and I've got a recording session with Jay Ungar and Molly Mason and a steel guitar player and a studio drummer and bass player and a few other people. A few songs are from my album that I'm making for Arbors Jazz, and a few songs will be for an album that I'm producing for this lady who sings for swing dances up in the Albany area. So since none of this pays very well,

I'm putting it all together, so everybody who participates can make a little money. And so that's what I'm doing on Wednesday. And let's see. Oh no, Tuesday I'm playing someplace for Mardi Gras. Wednesday I'm doing the recording. Thursday, either Thursday or Friday I've got some kind of — it's either a demo or self-produced album that someone is doing, like some singer-songwriter. And that's about all I remember so far.

MR: Well every day is different then.

PE: Right.

MR: And do you handle your own business?

PE: Yeah. Only really famous musicians have agents, because there's not enough money in any one job to really justify the trouble. It's not like booking someone for a movie or something like that.

MR: Yeah. Did it take a while to establish your reputation in New York?

PE: Well yeah I guess so. I mean I was able to start working, I really did pretty well when I started out in the '70s. It was very different then from how it is now. But I got in with a lot of singer-songwriters who wanted like horn arrangements and things, there was a lot of recording going on. So I did that. And I was also playing some traditional jazz. So that's really how I got started as a full time musician.

MR: Do you ever travel overseas?

PE: Yeah. I go overseas quite often. I'm going, next time will be in June actually. But I've worked in France quite a bit over the past ten years, also in Germany.

MR: Is it this kind of setting, where you're playing with just an ensemble of guys who hopefully know the same genre of music?

PE: Well it's a little more organized then that. Mostly in France I play with French musicians. There's one group I play with that plays maybe just four or five times a year. It's myself and three French trumpet players and a rhythm section, and it's not a terribly slick group but it's something that people seem to like, so it's fun to do. And then I play some festivals in Europe, mostly with European musicians. Those are organized kind of informally but it's with people I've played with before.

MR: Do they approach the music differently at all?

PE: Yeah. I mean everybody, it's funny everybody aspires or pretends to aspire to play authentic jazz, but in fact nobody really plays it the way it was because I mean even in America, we're in America today, not in the America of the '20s, '30s and '40s. So there's this whole other experience we have of like playing music that's happened since then and in Europe they have other musical traditions that you can't help affecting how people play, even if they're playing the same notes. And I think that's fine, it just gives things character and makes it more interesting.

MR: No one plays like the music was played in the ‘20s and ‘30s.

PE: Well I mean there’s some people who play very well but it’s not the ‘20s and ‘30s. So in that sense—

MR: A musician can’t divorce themselves from all the things that are happening now or have happened since then?

PE: Well I guess you could, but just people’s experience in music is different now. I mean most of that music was for dancing. And I lately have been playing a lot more for dancing. But when I was playing this music it mostly wasn’t for dancing. And that affects very greatly how it’s played and how you play. And most people’s experience of music now is television and recordings. And just the way people experience music is very different from, especially from before the 1920s, before the big boom in the record business in the 1920s. Peoples’ experience in music was just very different.

MR: To go actually hear it.

PE: To go hear it, or to hear player pianos, or to create it themselves by playing the piano and singing, and like that.

MR: We talked a little bit I think before the camera was rolling about this festival and the future of this festival, these kinds of festivals. And you had mentioned the trad jazz festival. Now the organizers of these festivals, when they say “trad jazz” can you tell us what they mean by that?

PE: They mean organized bands, mostly not full time musicians — some of them very good, some of them not so good — that play a more organized repertory than — and maybe not with the same expertise that you get here — but that put on more of a show. And sometimes it’s a very hokey show, sometimes a good show, but those — and have a following, usually developed by playing in some local club and having a mailing list. A lot of these bands that are of part time musicians are really much more business-like than full time musicians because this is what they do when they’re not at the office, and they use the same skills. I mean marketing and mailing lists and Internet and all that. And some of them are very good and do very well.

MR: That’s very interesting you know, like the band like The Bearcats and all those kind of local things, and so if you go to those things you’re going to see a group of people who’ve played together a lot, rehearsed—

PE: Right. I mean a band I fill in for sometimes, the new Black Eagle Band in Boston, they’re mostly not full time musicians. And if you heard them individually you might or might not think that there was something special. But together they’ve got a real sound that’s kind of unmistakable. And they do very well. I mean I don’t know if they still do, but even though they all have jobs, that was a big part of their income.

MR: Well when did you first become aware of these kinds of festivals, the San Diego and the L.A. Classic Festival and those kinds of things? I mean they've been going on since I guess the '70s, Dick Gibson.

PE: Well Dick Gibson is a jazz party situation. That's a little different. The ones with the mostly amateur bands are more like Sacramento, like that. And there are more of them on the west coast. But it's a place to play and a place to acquire a following and like that. There's really only one in the east that I do with my own group, it's the one in Connecticut, and we played there with the Orphan Newsboys a few times, a group I play with with Marty Grosz.

MR: Do you find that if you do — is it word of mouth that gets you in these things?

PE: I guess so. I mean I really don't know. I don't do a great deal of promotion myself. I should be doing more, but I mean if you're a full time musician, the trouble is these jobs, I mean especially the trad jazz festivals, they don't really pay that well. They're good for acquiring a following and for selling lots of CDs, but they don't pay as well as some of the other work I do. So it's a little hard to get motivated to find that kind of work exclusively as opposed to some of the better paying work I do.

MR: It may actually cost you to come to one of these, the trad jazz festivals.

PE: Well it probably wouldn't cost me, but I might go and then get a call like to play some festival in Europe for three times as much money and have to turn it down because I'd already signed a contract here or some other place. I mean this is all not very interesting but it's kind of the mechanics of running a small business, which is basically what being a musician is.

MR: Yeah. You're a small businessman.

PE: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about getting involved in the PBS thing with Ken Burns.

PE: Well I've never met Ken Burns, and I've played on three of his soundtracks. I hear a lot about him, but I just know the people who do music for him.

MR: You know he's working on a jazz thing now.

PE: Yeah, that's what I've heard.

MR: Yeah.

PE: And since I've never met him, I've only the best things to say about him.

MR: But you did the civil war one, right?

PE: Well actually it's funny I've just played on a few cues. But for some reason my name was at the end of every single episode. And one of the cues that I played on, although it was only like maybe 45 seconds, it was really kind of interesting. It was during the siege of Petersburg there was a Confederate cornet player who played a particular tune at sundown I believe it was every day. And so there was nothing else going on except the

music for this particular 45 seconds. And for some reason a lot of people noticed that, even though it was basically pretty insignificant. So it's funny how those things work. I mean you do these recordings all the time and mostly you never hear about them. And every once in a while one of them people notice.

MR: You go hey — that's me. Are those things — is there a union standard fee for those kinds of—

PE: Yeah. Increasingly the work I do is not through the union, but there is, particularly, not just the fee but for re-use of the music for other purposes. That's always problem when you do something without a union contract. It can appear anywhere, it can be used a hundred times in a hundred different settings and you never see any more money.

MR: Well that reminds me of the articles you see in the union newspapers, you know, why you should be in the union, and why you should have a union contract.

PE: Well they're in a tough position because the music business keeps contracting all the time, and the truth is people don't really need music, and they don't need musicians either, they can get by with synthesizers and canned music that they can buy without having to pay any rights. So the musicians' union is in a difficult position.

MR: Yeah, increasingly.

PE: I'm glad to have something that I do that's kind of distinctive so that it's a little more difficult to replace what I do with a synthesizer — than if I were just — or a reading musician.

MR: When you did the PBS things, was this horn—

PE: I didn't have this horn then. It was a horn like that, yeah.

MR: Did it help to have an older horn for that sound?

PE: Well it's not really the age, it's the configuration of the pipe. Like it starts smaller than a trumpet here, and keeps getting larger and larger. These are different sizes. And so it's more conical and it has a more characteristically mellow tone — not as much as the flugelhorn, but kind of halfway between.

MR: I had to laugh when Marty was talking about — you know he was actually rehearsing you guys on stage, or handing out instant arrangements. He says I'll do this and you guys mutter behind him. Now when you set up your set, is it getting increasingly hard as the weeks, not as the weeks, as the days go by at these festivals, to set up, if you're the leader to do a set, because now you're thinking well gee those guys did that yesterday? Does it cut down on your repertory choices?

PE: It should. In fact, I don't hear every set so I might play something tonight that's already been played. The problem with this particular event is that there are so many horn players. There are not that many tunes, as you know, that can fall into harmonies easily that sound good with harmonizing the lead like that. I mean if we tried to play "Deep

Purple" with four horns or something, we'd be in big trouble. And that really limits the repertory and also you have to give everybody solos, because that's why they're here, so it tends to make the tunes too long. And it's really kind of difficult to make consistently interesting music. Marty I think is one of the best at that. I mean at least he really makes an effort.

MR: He's certainly got a sense of humor too.

PE: Yeah.

MR: Do you have any beefs with the music business these days that you run across in your particular field?

PE: Well I suppose I should. I mean you get so used to taking things as they are and trying to find a way to take advantage of them. But that sort of discourages — I mean it's easier to have beefs if you have some other means of support.

MR: Good point.

PE: But we're in kind of an interesting time now I think because I mean when I was younger, rock was sort of the all-encompassing — it was the only music that a lot of people my age thought should ever exist or —

MR: Or did.

PE: Or did, yes. But now I think it's getting kind of played out so it's actually more interesting in general in the music business now that it's so fragmented and that there's so many styles. I mean there's always a lot of mediocrity, and there's certainly plenty of mediocrity now, but there's no like one thing that has everyone's imagination. So I think although the business, it's not a very good time to be a musician, it's sort of an interesting time to be around music.

MR: Well there's certainly a lot of styles: Cajun music and things that are kind of surfacing.

PE: Well there's a lot of focus on the past just in general, in all kinds of music. I mean rock music now, pop music, I just did a tour with the singer Madeleine Peyroux, and opening for Sarah McLachlan who's like a pop singer, and I got to know the musicians and the music, and I've kind of been away from that scene for a while. And it's like musicians who play pop music basically study everything that's happened in the past thirty or forty years and kind of synthesize things, sort of the way I've done with traditional jazz. It's not like everybody's rushing out to buy the latest album by so-and-so, to find out what the new things are to do, because there really aren't any. There are just kind of new instruments and new ways of mixing old stuff together. And that seems to be true across the board in most kinds of music and some of the more interesting music that's happening now I think is mixtures of things that have been around for a while. And I think in music that's generally the way things are. But it's like since we have this — I guess maybe since the turn of the century music is kind of a generational thing. Each

generation has to kind of destroy the music of the past and create a new kind of music. But the trouble is now they've sort of run out of things to do.

MR: Did I see on your little resume here that you had played with The Grateful Dead?

PE: Well I recorded with them. I played for a long time with a guy named David Bromberg who is—

MR: Oh, sure.

PE: I played in his band for about six years. That's really I think what makes me different from a lot of other musicians is I had that experience, like just music like that which is basically a mixture of many kinds of American music. It was basically a band that played traditional music of many different kinds, kind of gussied up with a rock rhythm section. And David is a very good showman so it's a band that I think the records were never quite as good as the shows, but that was a really great experience. I learned a lot of stuff about Country music and Bluegrass and old-timey music like Celtic music and Blues and things that trumpet players who are like spending their lives sitting on the bus in Stan Kenton's orchestra just never get exposed to. So I mean in a way that kind of held me back from being a super accomplished big band player and like that, but I really learned a lot of music that way so it was a really great experience.

MR: But you have done some big band playing?

PE: Oh yeah. Since the '70s I've gotten a lot better at that stuff, so actually I do that a fair amount but that's not how I started. That's how a lot of horn players start.

MR: I've heard there's a number of functioning big bands in New York.

PE: Yeah.

MR: Do you get involved and get calls to do that kind of thing?

PE: Yeah. I'm not really in any one of them, but I'm kind a sub for a lot of them. I kind of prefer that actually because you get a lot of different experiences. There's one I've played with run by a guy names Tony Corbiscello that's really very good, that does like '50s and '60s stuff, which is music that I really know less well than others, so it's really a lot of fun to do that. But another band that does 1920s music, which is a bit like a band I used to play with called Vince Giordano's Nighthawks, so those are the big bands I'm playing with occasionally now.

MR: Vince is the bass saxophonist, is that right?

PE: Yeah.

MR: And his music is based on the bands of the '20s?

PE: Yes.

MR: Like whom?

PE: Well he was thinking of I guess with the name Coon-Sander's Nighthawks, and Don Redman, Fletcher Henderson, all the dance orchestras, Jean Goldkette, all of those.

MR: Now what kind of functions in New York City does a band like that play?

PE: Well he had quite a bit of success, especially in the late '80s and early '90s doing society parties, because his band had kind of an elegant sound. He's play a certain amount of more standard dance music like shuffles and a few rock tunes, but basically the 1920s. And so I'd say society parties and fund raising events and things like that. He's out of the music business now except for as a sideman, but he had a number of good years doing that.

MR: If you had a nephew or something like that, or a niece that was going to aspire to be a musician, like yourself, would you have any words of advice for them?

PE: Well I think it's really important — you have to be able to play your instrument well and have a lot of certain basic skills, because it will hold you back if you don't, like being able to read music and play in tune and listen carefully to what other people are doing and play with good rhythm. And then it's also important to know certain things really well, to really master as many styles as you can. But there are a lot of people that do one without the other and sooner or later it catches up with them.

MR: Did you go to music school?

PE: No.

MR: So your training came mostly from listening and experience?

PE: Well I took lessons and I took music courses in college, although I didn't major in music. And I played in orchestras and like that. But that actually turned out to be a pretty good background, I think better than the jazz education I see now, a lot of which — I mean some of it is very good, but a lot of it seems to me to be just a way to get people to play something that sounds a little bit like jazz quickly and efficiently without necessarily knowing exactly what they're doing, or really playing anything very good. But that's all been mostly created since I was in college. I really don't know a lot about it. Sometimes I'm impressed and sometimes I'm not.

MR: It certainly has been put into the institutions, and there's lots and lots of things you can buy to help you.

PE: Yeah. But I think just by itself jazz is a little too narrow. I mean it's something that you could devote your life to after you decide either to be a professional musician or someone who plays music a lot, but it's a way of learning music. But to start with that as an exclusive approach to music I think is a little bit stupid. It's like deciding that you're only going to study nineteenth century art songs or something like that.

MR: No that's a good analogy actually. I mean the history of jazz is not that old to go to school specifically just to do that.

PE: And it's composed of so many elements that are also very old, I think it's really more important to know what it comes from as much as it is to know what it is. And if you're

talking like the kind of flowering period of jazz in the '50s and '60s, that's really a very short time. And it's also extremely difficult music to play well. I'd say, I mean I like bebop when it's played well, but it almost never is. It's really very difficult music. And when you put on one of those great Blue Note albums and then you hear like some modern day group, I think it's probably, it falls short even more than the efforts of myself and my friends to play old music, it falls short, if for no other reason than the music is more difficult.

MR: Anybody out there you enjoy listening to today?

PE: Oh yeah. Well I like some of the players here. Among the sort of younger generation of players, I think the one I like — I like Roy Hargrove, he's very good. A lot of them I'm not really that familiar with. You know how it is in music, there's some things that you recognize that are very good but they just don't happen to appeal to you.

MR: You can recognize the talent but it's not necessarily your—

PE: Right, what interests you.

MR: Any plans for recording coming up soon? You mentioned your own project.

PE: Yeah. Well I'm doing another album for Arbors Jazz, which is kind of a mixture of, it's mostly original music actually, and it's music inspired by situations I've been in and it's all instrumental of course, but it's music that seems to be pretty conservative to me but it's not exactly old jazz, it's not exactly anything, it's kind of mixture of things. I did an album like that for Arbors, which I really respect Mat Domber for encouraging me to do that, because it's not exactly the kind of music he has, although it's really pretty conservative. And I don't know that it sold a lot but it got some nice reviews so I'll continue in that direction. I try to perform that music as much as I can, of course I can't do it here, or I might try one piece in my own set which is coming up later.

MR: Well it's nice to be able to write your own stuff and have an outlet for it too, because someone should be writing tunes for the future.

PE: Well that's one odd thing about traditional jazz is that no one does it. I mean every other kind of music I played, everyone did that as a matter of course, and no one thought very much of it either but for some reason it's like you only play the great songs of the '20s, '30s, and '40s.

MR: Yeah. I suppose they're looking out there at the audience.

PE: Well I mean that too.

MR: Well I wish you a lot of luck with your future recordings and I hope that we run into you again at one of these festivals.

PE: Yeah, well, nice talking to you.

MR: And good luck coming up with a nicely balanced set, considering the line of horn players you've got to work with.

PE: Right. I think it's like three trumpet players or something like that. Maybe we'll do "Carnival of Venice."

MR: Yeah. "Bugler's Holiday."

PE: "Bugler's Holiday." And maybe Mahler's Fifth.

MR: As Tommy Newsom says, "That would be— this song's called clear the room."

PE: Right.

MR: Thanks for your time.